

Chapter 142-1

The cold winter wind rustled as the group stood at the entrance of the art museum, inadvertently forming quite a striking scene.

Liang Shi's response was neither servile nor overbearing.

Her face no longer held the world-weary look from before—at most, there was just a hint of indifference and barely perceptible disgust.

She simply disliked this person, that's all.

When speaking with Qin Lishuang, she didn't suppress her emotions, but she was much gentler than before.

Yet she wouldn't give anyone the impression that she was easy to bully.

Qin Lishuang was momentarily stunned by her words, and only after a moment did she recover her smile. "Here to see the exhibition?"

"What else?" Liang Shi retorted. "I couldn't possibly be here specifically waiting for the great painter Qin."

A slight edge showing through.

Qin Lishuang clicked her tongue and casually reached out to pat Liang Shi's shoulder, but Liang Shi took a step back to avoid it.

That hand hung suspended in the air, looking rather awkward.

"You've grown up." Qin Lishuang's fingers curled slightly in the air before she nonchalantly withdrew them, commenting with a light laugh: "More flavorful now."

Hearing this description, it didn't sound like she was evaluating a person at all.

And saying this right in front of Liang Shi's face meant she wasn't taking Liang Shi seriously.

Only those in positions of power would be so brazen when facing those beneath them.

But in terms of status and position, Qin Lishuang wasn't much higher than Liang Shi—they were about equal.

The only thing she had over Liang Shi was being a few years older.

Yet when Qin Lishuang looked at Liang Shi, she looked exactly like a master looking at a pet.

As long as the master beckoned, no matter where you ran off to, you, the pet, would have to come back.

Even facing Liang Shi's disgust and indifference, she still smiled with confidence, as if certain that Liang Shi couldn't resist.

Her current composure was merely a coat Liang Shi was wearing, while the real her was still a pitiful creature.

Liang Shi was actually a bit taller than her. She glanced at her lightly and said coldly: "I can't compare to you. Time doesn't seem to have been very kind to you lately."

She deliberately emphasized the formal "you,"¹ carrying a mocking tone.

Qin Lishuang wasn't annoyed. "Little Liang Shi, you're becoming more and more adorable."

Liang Shi let out a light scoff.

Qin Lishuang said: "I had already lost interest in you, but the way you are now has made me somewhat..."

She paused, her eyes roving over Liang Shi's body. "How about it? Would you like to... be my model again~?"

Qin Lishuang had a rather seductive appearance—a pair of fox-like eyes, wearing light purple colored contacts. Although she was a bit older than Liang Shi, she wasn't yet forty, and with how well she maintained herself, her skin was clear and translucent. So visually, it looked like Qin Lishuang was seducing Liang Shi.

Qin Lishuang's nails were very long, painted in a mix of gold and silver today. Catching Liang Shi off guard, she raised her hand and hooked Liang Shi's chin, her fingernail rubbing against Liang Shi's chin. "Right now, I'm very interes—"

Before she could finish the word "interested," Liang Shi bent her finger back.

Liang Shi bent her finger back to nearly a ninety-degree angle. In that instant, everyone present heard the sound of finger bones cracking—quite loudly too.

Qin Lishuang furrowed her brows, no longer as composed as before. "What are you doing?"

"That's what I should be asking you." Liang Shi said coldly: "What does Miss Qin think she's doing? Just because you're older means you can do whatever you want? In public like this, don't think that just because your reputation is already ruined you can act however you please. Do you even remember your surname? Does the Qin family know that Miss Qin conducts herself like this?"

In any case, Qin Lishuang's finger was in Liang Shi's grip, the fingertip bright red as if all the blood had been forced there.

Qin Lishuang tried to pull her hand free but couldn't match Liang Shi's strength.

"Mind your own business." Qin Lishuang retorted.

Liang Shi didn't listen and continued on her own: "Oh right, the Qin family does know. It's precisely because Old Master Qin dotes on Miss Qin that Miss Qin is so brazen. However... Old Master Qin seems to be on his last legs? Miss Qin should take it easy. Don't play with fire—when the time comes, you won't even know how you died."

Her brows and eyes were distant, her expression bland—she was simply stating facts.

But to Qin Lishuang's ears, it took on a different meaning. "Are you threatening me?"

"Not at all." Liang Shi said: "Advice."

Qin Lishuang wanted to say something more, but the person wearing the baseball cap beside her tugged at her. The voice was clear and crisp, urging: "Alright, let's go."

It wasn't the tone of someone trying to mediate—just impatience.

That person's way of speaking was quite blunt, far more direct than Liang Shi's earlier veiled barbs.

Judging by the voice, the other person wasn't that old either—definitely younger than Qin Lishuang, at least.

Yet Qin Lishuang didn't get angry when she heard her say that. After freezing in place for a moment, she answered with a hint of deference: "Understood."

When she looked at Liang Shi again, she had already put on a different demeanor. "Little Liang Shi, you really should go inside and take a look."

"Look at what?" Liang Shi asked.

Qin Lishuang sneered: "Look at what you did a few years ago."

"The you right now is like a cat." Qin Lishuang said: "I still prefer you with a bit of fire in you."

Liang Shi paused for a moment, then asked with genuine feeling: "What does what you like have to do with me?"

Liang Shi's voice was very cold: "I don't like you."

Qin Lishuang's expression changed.

But Liang Shi continued: "This narcissistic personality of yours—has it always been like this?"

The implication being—how long have you had this condition?

Qin Lishuang: "..."

After a moment, Qin Lishuang's eyes sparkled with scattered light. Far from being angry, there was even a hint of frivolous amusement in her smile. "Very good. You've piqued my interest once again."

"But what can be done?" Liang Shi applied force with her hand, bending her finger completely backward. Only after Qin Lishuang cried out in pain did she roughly fling her hand away. "I have absolutely no interest in you."

Qin Lishuang: "..."

"Auntie."² Liang Shi said: "One should have some self-awareness."

Footnotes:

¹ **Formal "you"** (您): In Chinese, "您" (nín) is the formal/polite form of "you," typically used to show respect to elders or those of higher status. However, when used sarcastically as Liang Shi does here, emphasizing it becomes a way of mocking someone—implying they're old while pretending to be respectful.

² **Auntie** (阿姨): While this can be a respectful term for older women, in this context Liang Shi is using it sarcastically to emphasize Qin Lishuang's age, essentially calling her old as a final jab.

Chapter 142-2

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Qin Lishuang was driven away by Liang Shi's words.

The moment the word "Auntie" came out, Qin Lishuang's expression changed drastically. She gnashed her teeth and called out Liang Shi's name, but was urged on again by the person beside her: "Hurry up."

The way she spoke with the "er" sound¹ was natural and fluid—an authentic Beijing accent. It could be considered the most pleasant Beijing dialect Liang Shi had ever heard.

Qin Lishuang left feeling stifled.

Liang Shi watched the two figures departing. The woman in the gray tracksuit suddenly turned her head, and their gazes met unexpectedly.

That person had a pair of very indifferent eyes, as if she had seen through everything.

The other party was covered up tightly, with only her eyes showing.

But she quickly lowered her head, her eyes hidden beneath the baseball cap.

Chen Mian didn't follow them inside. After watching Qin Lishuang and that person enter, she withdrew her gaze and asked Liang Shi: "Do you two have bad blood?"

"Sort of." Liang Shi said.

"That woman isn't a decent person." Chen Mian scoffed lightly: "Stay away from her."

"I know." Liang Shi looked away. "Don't you still have an experience-sharing session? Go on, you'll be late."

Chen Mian glanced at her watch. "Ten minutes."

Liang Shi: "?"

It was only a moment later that Liang Shi understood that Chen Mian's "ten minutes" meant she would only be inside for ten minutes.

Because she had turned down the organizer's lunch gathering, she went in and very perfunctorily conducted an experience-sharing session, finishing with just a few brief remarks.

Everyone knew her temperament and didn't push it.

After Chen Mian came out, she instinctively went to sit in the back seat, only to find that Liang Wanwan was already sitting there.

So she went around to sit in the front passenger seat instead.

Liang Shi asked: "What do you want to eat?"

"Anything's fine." Chen Mian said: "Aren't you the one treating?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"I'm taking you to meet someone." Liang Shi said: "Do you mind?"

Chen Mian paused for a moment. "Gu Xingyue?"

Liang Shi: "...No."

Liang Shi started the car, her expression calm. "She won't see me right now. I'm taking you to pick up my wife for lunch."

Chen Mian's expression relaxed. She propped one hand against the car window, closed her eyes, and pretended to sleep. "Whatever you want."

Footnotes:

¹ **"Er" sound** (兒話音): A distinctive feature of the Beijing dialect where an "er" (兒) sound is added to the end of words, giving the speech a characteristic rolling quality. It's considered a hallmark of authentic Beijing Mandarin and can sound particularly pleasant and natural when spoken by native speakers.

Chapter 142-3

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Liang Shi had chosen a dining location near Xu Qingzhu's company, which happened to coincide with her lunch break.

It was Xu Qingzhu and Chen Mian's first time meeting. Neither of them talked much.

After Liang Shi introduced them to each other, things quieted down.

When they sat down, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were on one side, while Chen Mian and Liang Wanwan naturally sat together on the other side.

Liang Wanwan sat on the inside and didn't take off her coat.

It was a bit hot inside the restaurant. Chen Mian was the first to notice and asked casually: "Aren't you hot?"

"Huh?" Liang Wanwan looked toward Chen Mian, but after just one glance, she quickly averted her gaze. "No... a little..."

Her voice trembled as she spoke, nearly biting her own tongue. She kept her eyes lowered, biting her lower lip, cursing herself for being stupid in her heart.

She quickly took off her coat, but her palms were still damp.

Liang Wanwan glanced at Chen Mian from the corner of her eye.

Liang Shi even teased her: "Wanwan, sitting and eating with your idol shouldn't make you this nervous, right?"

"Huh?" Liang Wanwan stumbled over her words again. "It's... it's okay..."

She didn't even know what to say—there were no suitable words for her to express herself.

Xu Qingzhu took everything in and placed some food in Liang Wanwan's bowl, comforting her: "Don't listen to your sister's nonsense. Just eat."

Liang Wanwan picked up her chopsticks, her head lowered as far as it could go. Through the gaps in her hair, Xu Qingzhu could see her ears, red as if they were on fire.

Chen Mian didn't have much of a reaction.

She had always been unconventional. No matter who she was eating with, she never felt awkward—she just calmly ate the food in front of her.

Until a plate of stir-fried vegetables was brought to the table.

To make the dish look nice, plain white lily flowers had been placed on the edge of the plate as decoration.

Chen Mian stared at those lily flowers, briefly lost in thought. Liang Shi was about to start eating when Chen Mian grabbed her wrist. "Wait."

Liang Shi: "?"

Chen Mian took out her phone, snapped a photo of that dish, then said calmly: "Continue."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi ate a bite of food in a daze before it dawned on her. "Is it because Qi Jiao likes lily flowers?"

Chen Mian's hand holding the chopsticks paused, and she gave a small nod.

Suddenly, the meal didn't taste quite right anymore.

Chen Mian curved her lips into a smile, and warmth appeared in those world-weary eyes of hers: "The plating is quite nice."

"Mm." Liang Shi responded perfunctorily.

Everyone at this meal had their own preoccupations.

After hearing the name Qi Jiao, Liang Wanwan lowered her head, her hand holding the chopsticks even trembling slightly.

Xu Qingzhu observed them all without showing any sign of it.

As for Liang Shi, she was probably the one eating most carefreely.

After the meal, Chen Mian said she had things to do and needed to leave. Liang Wanwan also had to return to school.

When they compared notes, it turned out both of them were heading to the Communication University.

So Chen Mian hailed a taxi directly. After getting in, she called out: "Little sister, come on, let's go together."

Liang Wanwan stood in place, somewhat at a loss. She looked toward Liang Shi.

Liang Shi patted her shoulder: "Go back and study hard. If you need money, just tell me."

Liang Wanwan bit her lip. "Okay."

Her sweaty palms and rapidly beating heart made her somewhat resistant to sharing a car with Chen Mian.

Especially having to sit together in the back seat.

But she actually really wanted to.

In the end, she got in the car, though Chen Mian sat on the other side, quite far from her.

As if they didn't know each other.

The taxi drove off into the distance. Xu Qingzhu watched Liang Shi's back, while Liang Shi watched the car drive away.

After a moment, Liang Shi withdrew her gaze. When she turned around, she unexpectedly met Xu Qingzhu's eyes.

"What is it?" Liang Shi asked. "Why are you looking at me?"

"Because you're good-looking." Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled, her gaze softening.

Liang Shi: "..."

She stepped forward and took Xu Qingzhu's hand. "When are you going back up?"

"Whenever." Xu Qingzhu said: "I don't have any meetings this afternoon."

Liang Shi asked: "Don't you have other things to take care of?"

"They're not very important matters." Xu Qingzhu said: "So I can put them off for a while."

"You should still handle them." Liang Shi squeezed her fingers. "Otherwise you'll have to bring work home again tonight."

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu turned her head and raised an eyebrow. "Teacher Liang."

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

"You have a lot of objections to me working at home?" Xu Qingzhu said.

The winter wind was strong. The two walked very close together, and Xu Qingzhu's voice sounded as if it were right by her ear.

Liang Shi immediately denied it: "How could I? I'm just worried you won't sleep well at night."

"If you'd stop messing around for a bit," Xu Qingzhu said, "I'd be able to sleep well."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi sheepishly touched the tip of her nose. Knowing she was in the wrong, she leaned in close to her ear and said: "It's just that you're too lovable."

"But I won't mess around tonight." Liang Shi promised: "I'll let you sleep well."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "Really?"

Liang Shi: "More real than pearls."¹

Footnotes:

¹ **More real than pearls** (比珍珠還真): A Chinese expression used to emphasize that something is absolutely true/genuine. It plays on the word "真" (zhēn) which means both "real/true" and sounds similar to "珍" (zhēn) in "珍珠" (pearl). It's a playful way of saying "absolutely true" or "I swear it's real."

Chapter 142-4

The two walked to the entrance of a milk tea shop. There happened to be a buy-two-get-a-discount promotion, so Xu Qingzhu went to buy two cups of milk tea.

When paying, she still didn't let Liang Shi do it.

After buying the milk tea, the two went to wait in the car. Both tacitly sat in the back seat.

Xu Qingzhu held her milk tea and nestled into Liang Shi's arms. "When are you joining the production crew?"

"Not sure yet." Liang Shi said: "Probably another week?"

"Alright."

Liang Shi's hand happened to be resting on her shoulder. She lifted it slightly and let it fall on her face, giving it a gentle pinch. "What's wrong? Already don't want to see me anymore?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu said: "It's just... I have to go on a business trip."

"When?" Liang Shi asked.

"If you're going to film in a week, then I'll..." Xu Qingzhu gave a soft cough. "Also go in a week."

Liang Shi was surprised: "Huh?"

Xu Qingzhu burrowed into her embrace, her head just happening to brush against her softness. "I don't want to leave."

Her voice was very soft, making Liang Shi's heart itch.

Liang Shi pinched her face again, but this time she couldn't bear to let go. Her fingernails caressed the side of her face. "Xu Qingzhu, why are you so..."

"What?" Xu Qingzhu said: "Do you want me to go on a business trip?"

Liang Shi: "...Not really."

"It's just that you being like this..." Liang Shi paused mid-sentence. Xu Qingzhu had already moved very close to her. The unopened milk tea was casually set aside, rolling on the car seat.

Then it rolled off the seat with a gurgling sound and fell to the floor.

Xu Qingzhu's hand landed on Liang Shi's shoulder as she slightly tilted her head up to look at Liang Shi.

Her hand slowly moved, coming to rest on Liang Shi's neck.

The cool touch of her hand made Liang Shi shiver. Before long, Xu Qingzhu's hand settled behind her ear.

Her glands grew slightly warm.

Liang Shi licked her lips, her throat making a sound—very low.

But in such a quiet environment, it was clearly audible.

Liang Shi's lips looked as if they were coated with lip gloss. Xu Qingzhu stared at her intently.

"Teacher Liang." Xu Qingzhu moved closer to her, the warm breath of her words spilling entirely onto her skin. "You didn't finish what you were saying. What's wrong with me being like this?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Having reached this point, even someone as slow as Liang Shi had caught on.

More accurately, her body's instincts reacted faster than her brain did in this regard.

Liang Shi's body felt somewhat hot.

The warm air blowing inside the car made one drowsy. Xu Qingzhu was wearing a white turtleneck base layer sweater, a very fitted style that showed off her graceful curves.

Now pressed close against her, one of her legs naturally hooked around Liang Shi's.

A tiny bit of sweat appeared on the tip of Liang Shi's nose.

"You being like this..." Liang Shi's voice trembled slightly, but she still couldn't finish her sentence.

She had wanted to say it was too love-brained¹ and not conducive to Xu Qingzhu's career development.

But her instincts told her that if she said that, Xu Qingzhu would get angry.

Perhaps because the atmosphere had reached this point, Liang Shi didn't want to ruin Xu Qingzhu's mood with such words either.

Xu Qingzhu pressed down on her glands.

The sensation was very pleasant. Liang Shi could barely hold back... yet she said softly: "Stop messing around."

But these words carried no deterrent power—to anyone's ears, they sounded no different from flirting.

"How am I messing around?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi looked at her, her gaze somewhat hazy. Xu Qingzhu's lips were very red, like sugar-coated hawthorns,² glistening brightly.

"Didn't you just tell me to stop messing around?" Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Yes, but I never said I wouldn't mess around."

These words made absolutely no sense.

And they weren't even fair.

Yet Liang Shi was helpless against her.

And she quite enjoyed it.

Liang Shi smiled helplessly, her hand resting on her hair, indulging her: "Then how do you want to mess around?"

"You first." Xu Qingzhu said: "What were you just saying about me being like this?"

Even while questioning her, Xu Qingzhu wasn't being well-behaved—her hand gently caressed Liang Shi's neck.

The skin on Liang Shi's neck was very fair.

Xu Qingzhu bit it once. "Tell me."

The tip of Liang Shi's sweaty nose touched hers as she lifted her up from her embrace, her throat moving slightly.

Their eyes met. Liang Shi's hand fell to the back of her head, her fingers entangled in strands of her hair.

Liang Shi smiled helplessly, her light brown eyes full of indulgence.

Her voice was very low: "You being like that... I like it very much."

Xu Qingzhu smiled upon hearing this.

Liang Shi's hand applied slight pressure, and Xu Qingzhu leaned in, her body very soft.

When Xu Qingzhu kissed Liang Shi, she was quite intense.

Not intense in the conventional sense—she simply wanted to take in more.

From a psychological perspective, this seemed like very insecure behavior.

Craving to use these things to prove that the other person existed, that the other person loved her.

Liang Shi was too hot and cold.

Xu Qingzhu felt that Liang Shi treated her very well, but... it wasn't enough.

Xu Qingzhu wanted her to be even better.

All of Liang Shi's gentleness and consideration were based on the fact that—she was her wife.

If that identity were stripped away, Liang Shi didn't have much love for her.

In this relationship, she seemed to always be in a state where she could withdraw at any moment.

It had been this way from the very beginning.

Xu Qingzhu bit her tongue, then soothed her—but in reality, she was soothing her own emotions.

Xu Qingzhu knew that Liang Shi wasn't being good to her out of genuine feelings or because she liked her. From the very beginning, her kindness had come with ulterior motives. But she didn't mind.

In the past, when she hadn't gotten close, when she hadn't obtained it, that was one thing.

But now that she had gotten close, now that she had obtained it, she wanted more.

Xu Qingzhu felt herself becoming increasingly greedy.

But she wanted to hear Liang Shi praise her, wanted Liang Shi to look at her, wanted Liang Shi to... love her.

After the lingering, passionate kiss, Xu Qingzhu leaned close to Liang Shi's ear and whispered: "Jiejie~ I'm so greedy."

Footnotes:

¹ **Love-brained** (戀愛腦): A Chinese internet slang term describing someone who becomes completely consumed by romantic feelings, often to the detriment of other aspects of their life such as career, friendships, or rational decision-making. It implies being so head-over-heels in love that one loses perspective.

² **Sugar-coated hawthorns** (糖山楂): A traditional Chinese snack called "tanghulu" (糖葫蘆) or candied hawthorn berries. The hawthorn fruits are skewered on a stick and coated in hardened sugar syrup, giving them a bright red, glossy appearance. It's a popular street food, especially in northern China during winter.